

Chapter 112-1

Gu Xingyue had come out during a break between classes. She would have to go back soon to continue teaching the children.

Liang Shi didn't ask why she had suddenly been placed under Yang Jiani's strict supervision again recently. She only indirectly inquired about her current situation.

Gu Xingyue took a sip of tea and said faintly, "Not dead yet, so I suppose that counts as okay?"

That one sentence left Liang Shi speechless.

But after a moment, Liang Shi said very seriously, "Be a little kinder to yourself."

Gu Xingyue looked at her. "What's the use? Life hasn't treated me any better because of it."

"That's exactly why you need to be better to yourself." Liang Shi said, "I will help you escape from your current life, so you need to hold on."

When Liang Shi said this, her gaze was intense.

Gu Xingyue suddenly lowered her head and laughed at the sight.

There was some bitterness in that laugh.

"Why are you helping me?" Gu Xingyue asked. "Isn't it just to bring Qi Jiao's matter to light?"

"I can't deny that's part of the reason." Liang Shi didn't hide it. "But I think you shouldn't be anyone's stand-in."

Qi Jiao was Qi Jiao, and Gu Xingyue was Gu Xingyue.

When encountering such situations, Liang Shi's thinking was: help whenever you can.

Within the scope of what was possible.

What's more, Qi Jiao from childhood had been kind to her.

She also wanted to return this name to Qi Jiao.

Many things are done without reason, simply guided by emotion. In a daze, you look back and find you've already come so far.

Having already come this far, you can't just give up at a time like this.

Bad people should always receive punishment.

Liang Shi had once seen written on the title page of a book: "No man is an island."

If it were before, after investigating to this point, she might have given up. She wouldn't have been so determined to help Gu Xingyue escape this cage.

But after being here for over two months, her thinking had also changed.

She herself was no longer an island. Someone had barged into her life and brought her warmth she had never experienced before.

She had received so much, so she wanted to do what she could to bring Gu Xingyue out of her island as well.

Gu Xingyue treated people sincerely and was kind-hearted. Despite having experienced so much hardship, she ranked first as the most beloved teacher among the children at the kindergarten.

Children's eyes never lie.

What reason was there for such a person to remain imprisoned in a cage?

Liang Shi said sincerely, "You should have a better life—one that belongs to Gu Xingyue."

Rather than continuing to live under Qi Jiao's name.

Gu Xingyue's hands rested on her legs, her eyes downcast.

There was a gentle light flowing in her eyes. The shocking mark on her wrist revealed that she had just gone through a struggle not long ago.

This was a scene that occasionally appeared during her more than ten years of playing Qi Jiao.

She needed to show Gu Xingyue's rebellious edge on various major life decisions, using harm to her own body as a bargaining chip, in order to obtain a slightly more normal chance at life.

For example, when choosing a university, she wanted to stay in Haizhou City. Yang Jiani wanted her to choose oil painting because Qi Jiao had been talented in art.

But Gu Xingyue chose early childhood education. When Yang Jiani tried to change her application, she used this method to achieve a brief victory.

Another example was her job after graduation. Having grown up in an orphanage, she loved children and wanted to become a kindergarten teacher.

But Yang Jiani really wanted her to work at a library because Qi Jiao used to love reading and had said she thought being a librarian was the warmest profession in the world.

Gu Xingyue didn't agree. Instead, she fought against her once more, earning the opportunity to work at this kindergarten.

At all other times, she was Qi Jiao.

Quiet, docile, obedient—Qi Jiao without any thoughts of her own.

Qi Jiao who suppressed all her emotions deep in her heart, who didn't dare to get close to anyone.

Gu Xingyue had once been taught by the director: one must be independent and self-reliant, not depending on anyone else for survival. Don't be vulgar, don't be sharp. Be smooth when you can be smooth, and show your blade when you can't. You can't always be like fire, nor can you always be like water. Fire and water are incompatible, yet they must coexist.

Chapter 112-2

"Do you know?" After a long silence, Gu Xingyue raised her hand and placed it on the table, not hiding the mark on her wrist. Her voice was very light and soft as she changed the direction of the topic. "I used to always think that compromising and enduring everything would make things better for everyone. But now I've realized that compromising only makes bad people become even worse."

"I was abandoned at the orphanage." Gu Xingyue said, "The director said that when he found me, I was only a few months old. At that time, my face had broken out in a large rash, and I could barely cry anymore. One of my feet was wrapped in bandages—there was something wrong with my leg. If I cried too long, my heart would become oxygen-deprived. But even then, I didn't die."

Liang Shi listened quietly, her heart involuntarily tightening.

Hearing such things always made one feel sad along with them.

"The illnesses in my body are because I cried for a very long time as a child. I didn't die, but I was left with a bunch of chronic conditions. My heart isn't good, so I can't do vigorous exercise. I can't handle too much stimulation. When my emotions get too intense, I faint. I walk and react half a beat slower than others. It's probably what people nowadays often call having a strong 'dull sense.'¹" Gu Xingyue spoke at an unhurried pace, calm and composed as if telling someone else's story, her emotions without much fluctuation.

"They all say having a strong dull sense is a good thing, but my dull sense is different from ordinary people's. I react to things half a beat slower, and my emotions also respond half a beat slower—it's just that I don't feel sad in the moment. But I'm fine. Becoming Qi Jiao has already become a part of my life. I've never even thought about how I should live as Gu Xingyue." Gu Xingyue also laid her cards on the table very honestly with Liang Shi. "I never thought about cooperating with you, nor did I think about giving you Qi Jiao's diary. I've always felt that you were speaking without knowing the pain²—you don't know what I've been through. All you've experienced was only the earliest version of Yang Jiani's madness."

How crazy Yang Jiani became later was beyond what a normal person could imagine.

"I dare say that if I died now, she would immediately rush to find the next replacement without stopping." Gu Xingyue said coldly, "And she could grind my bones to ashes and whip my corpse ten thousand times."

Maybe even more than that.

This woman's obsession and possessiveness had reached an appalling level.

"The reason I'm telling you all this is to say—" Gu Xingyue paused, then looked at Liang Shi sincerely.

Their eyes met. Liang Shi saw a firm light in Gu Xingyue's eyes. "I'm willing to trust you now. But if you want to run away halfway, I won't blame you either. I just hope you can pass my letter to my brother."

"I won't run away." Liang Shi said, "This battle—I can fight alongside you until the very end."

She couldn't accompany Qi Jiao back then, so now she would accompany Gu Xingyue.

Bad people must always pay the price.

The truth may be late, but it must arrive.

"Whether you're there or not." Gu Xingyue curved her lips into a smile, her fingernails tracing over the blue-green porcelain cup. Her long eyelashes fluttered, and in her eyes was a firm light that had never been there before. "I will take back everything."

All the hardships and grievances she had experienced over these years—she would reclaim them all.

For no other reason than that she wanted to be Gu Xingyue now.

What use was someone else's thirty percent of sincerity?

Better to fight for it herself.

At worst, things would just stay as they were.

-
1. "Dull sense" (鈍感力, *dunganli*) refers to a psychological concept popularized in East Asia, meaning the ability to be less sensitive to negative stimuli, criticisms, or stressful situations. It's often seen as a form of emotional resilience or thick-skinnedness. ↩
 2. "Speaking without knowing the pain" (站着說話不腰疼) is a Chinese idiom that literally translates to "one's back doesn't hurt when standing and talking." It means it's easy to give advice or make comments when you're not the one suffering or dealing with the problem. ↩

Chapter 112-3

//

Gu Xingyue couldn't stay here for too long. After talking with Liang Shi, she had to hurry back to school.

She didn't have a driver's license, nor did she have a car. Normally, a driver would pick her up and drop her off for work. In situations like this, Yang Jiani would keep her under strict control, so she would be picked up and dropped off for work.

But this was only for a period of time.

Once she became docile and turned back into Qi Jiao again, putting away her fangs, Yang Jiani would return some of her freedom.

After leaving the tea house, Liang Shi offered to drive her back to the kindergarten, but Gu Xingyue refused.

Gu Xingyue took a taxi and left. Liang Shi stood in place for a while, processing her emotions alone.

Compared to Gu Xingyue, everything she had experienced seemed like nothing.

Liang Shi felt melancholic. It was only after getting back into the car that she took out Qi Jiao's diary.

Gu Xingyue was a very meticulous person. When transcribing Qi Jiao's diary, she first copied it out in Morse code, with the translation on the back.

This made it convenient for Liang Shi to read.

Gu Xingyue had probably almost memorized this diary by now. Most of the content in the diary was about daily life.

Qi Jiao didn't have any friends at school, and she didn't dare make friends with anyone.

But actually, her appearance was the type that people liked—the girl-next-door look, pure and cute. She should have been liked by many people at school.

Yet because of her strange quietness, everyone was afraid to talk to her.

Qi Jiao even got a new desk mate in middle school. After sitting together for a week, her desk mate finally said in surprise, "So you're not a mute after all."

How laughable.

Qi Jiao's ability to express herself began to deteriorate rapidly. She often wanted to communicate with people but didn't know what to say. When facing strangers, she would become unusually nervous, stammering for a long time without being able to get a single sentence out, her face flushing red with embarrassment, not knowing what to do.

So her classmates all thought she had social anxiety.

But actually she didn't. She really wanted to blend in with everyone.

But Yang Jiani didn't like that.

Yang Jiani hated Qi Jiao having any social circle whatsoever. She wished Qi Jiao would only revolve around her alone.

Qi Jiao's life belonged to Yang Jiani.

Qi Jiao also asked in her diary: 【Why can my life only have Mom in it, but Mom's life can have so many people?】

Qi Jiao's diary rarely mentioned Qi Xiangui¹, only a few brief strokes.

To her, the image of her father was very thin. He was a philistine, face-obsessed, extremely selfish businessman. He didn't have just her mother as a woman—Qi Jiao even saw him with another woman on their family sofa when she was twelve.

All the servants in the house knew that her father was cheating. Once she even heard the servants discussing it, saying that men with money all turn bad. So what if the madam's family used to be illustrious? There were plenty of families that were still illustrious now where the men still sought food outside². What's more, Yang Jiani's family was only illustrious in the past—now she was nothing but a fallen wealthy daughter.

Qi Jiao had also asked Yang Jiani why she didn't divorce him, why she didn't take her and leave.

In her innocence, Qi Jiao had once hoped that Yang Jiani would leave Qi Xiangui. That way, Yang Jiani would slowly return to normal.

But Yang Jiani looked at her with a cold smile and asked her back—where would they go? How would they live?

Qi Jiao had also heard Yang Jiani say that in this lifetime, she and Qi Xiangui would fight to the death³.

Qi Jiao wrote in her diary: 【It's very strange. "Fight to the death" should be a phrase used between enemies, but when Mother uses it on Father, I don't find it out of place. They only appear loving in front of cameras, in other people's eyes. I don't know—is everyone's life like this?】

【They wear the skin of hypocrisy and blend into the crowd. No one knows they're just a pack of beasts.】

【I seem to be just a tool, used to obtain emotional value and emotional needs, to become something to compete over and show off. I'm not supposed to have my own thoughts. If that's the case, why not just buy a doll? Or make a marionette—they don't have thoughts.】

【My soul was killed on this night. I'm willing to give up all of this. All these thoughts are meaningless. Life itself is a paradox. We study the origin of the universe, biological evolution, the theory of innate goodness versus innate evil⁴. But I think the things in textbooks are not enough to explain the complex species that is humanity.】

.....

It was hard not to feel sad after reading Qi Jiao's diary.

Especially since Liang Shi had met her, remembered her, and had many memories with her that weren't beautiful, but where only she was shining.

They had once promised to become kindergarten teachers together, to see the ocean together, to keep each other warm in the darkness, to be each other's source of light.

But unexpectedly, not a single one of their promises was fulfilled.

In what wasn't a very long time, she had forgotten Qi Jiao and missed the remainder of her brief life.

After finishing Qi Jiao's diary, Liang Shi put it in a hidden place before taking out her phone.

It was still on the chat page with Xu Qingzhu that she hadn't closed.

Yang Shuyan's personalized autograph was still hanging in the most prominent place.

Liang Shi typed on the screen: 【I just went to see Gu Xingyue, didn't check my phone.】

She explained why she hadn't replied to messages, then sent another: 【How did you get the autograph so quickly? I wanted to help with that.】

It happened to be Xu Qingzhu's break time, so she replied quickly: 【I happened to be signing a supplementary contract with Yang Shuyan today, so I got it.】

Liang Shi:

As expected of a capitalist.

Liang Shi: 【Alright then.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【Why do I feel like you're unhappy?】

Liang Shi: 【No.】

After a moment, Liang Shi added: 【I'm unhappy because I met with Gu Xingyue. I got Qi Jiao's complete diary.】

Xu Qingzhu's name changed to "the other party is typing," probably organizing her words.

After a long while, Xu Qingzhu sent a ten-second voice message.

That cool, clear voice spoke unhurriedly: "Her diary must be very sad to read. So, Teacher Liang, have you eaten? I'm a bit hungry. If you're not busy... um... could you come keep me company for a meal?"

When Xu Qingzhu spoke, there was no flirtatiousness at all. Her voice was much gentler than usual.

Just from her tone alone, Liang Shi's sadness was stirred up.

Xu Qingzhu hadn't comforted her, yet Liang Shi understood.

Originally, this emotion was something she could handle on her own and would digest quickly. But suddenly, someone said this to her.

Liang Shi felt the sad emotions multiply many times over, and she really wanted to find someone to talk to.

She sat there and replied: 【What a coincidence, I haven't eaten either. Give me ten minutes.】

-
1. Qi Xiangui (齊先貴) is Qi Jiao's father and Yang Jiani's husband. ⇐
 2. "Seeking food outside" (在外邊覓食) is a euphemism for having affairs or seeking romantic/sexual partners outside of marriage. ⇐
 3. "Fight to the death" (不死不休) literally means "won't rest until one is dead," indicating an irreconcilable conflict that will only end when one party dies. ⇐
 4. This refers to classical Chinese philosophical debates between Mencius (who believed human nature is inherently good) and Xunzi (who believed human nature is inherently evil). ⇐

Chapter 112-4

//

Driving from Gulang Pavilion to Minghui took only about ten minutes.

But the road was completely clear, and Liang Shi drove fast, arriving downstairs at Minghui in just eight minutes.

Liang Shi parked the car by the roadside and sent Xu Qingzhu another message: 【I'm here, come down.】

In less than two minutes, Xu Qingzhu's figure appeared downstairs at Minghui.

She also quickly spotted Liang Shi's car.

Xu Qingzhu opened the door and got in, her movements smooth and fluid.

She probably found her hair troublesome, so she had clipped it up with a white hair clip, leaving a few strands of hair on either side, making her hair look thick and full.

Today she wore a white fitted base layer top, black high-waisted wide-leg pants, and five-centimeter high heels. As soon as she got in the car, she took off her coat and tossed it in the back seat, only to discover that Liang Shi hadn't turned on the heater.

Xu Qingzhu rubbed her hands together. "Why didn't you turn on the heater?"

Liang Shi: "It's not that cold."

While saying this, she turned on the car's heater and naturally reached out to hold Xu Qingzhu's hand.

Ice cold.

Liang Shi frowned. "Have you seen a doctor? It's not even winter yet—what are you going to do when winter comes? Your hands and feet are this cold every day."

Xu Qingzhu said while fastening her seatbelt, "I've seen doctors. They all say it's a constitution issue and doesn't affect my health."

Liang Shi tried to warm her hands but found that no matter what, she couldn't warm them up. She asked where she wanted to go eat, and after asking, she muttered under her breath, "I'll have to buy you a hot water bottle to keep on hand from now on."

Xu Qingzhu named a Japanese restaurant that was nearby, just around the corner.

Liang Shi drove while Xu Qingzhu sat in the passenger seat, pretending to ask casually, "Are you feeling better now?"

"Much better." Liang Shi said, "I'll show you her diary when we get back tonight. Focus on work for now."

Xu Qingzhu acknowledged with a sound, then glanced sideways. Liang Shi was driving attentively.

"Did you take Wanwan back to school?" Xu Qingzhu asked again.

Liang Shi nodded. "Yes, right after I dropped off Wanwan, Qi Jiao called me."

Saying this, she suddenly remembered, "I might be back a bit late tonight."

"What for?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

"Big Brother asked me to bring Ling Dang back to the old residence." Liang Shi was a little excited talking about this. Even though the battle hadn't started yet, it was as if she could already see the dawn of victory. "To get justice for Ling Dang."

"Alright." Xu Qingzhu said, then added an assessment, "Big Brother is really dependable."

He could take care of everyone in the family. Everyone else thought children's matters were trivial and wouldn't pay much attention to them.

It was just being wrongly accused and suffering a bit of grievance—not a big deal.

But once Liang Xinzhou found out, he wouldn't let this matter go easily. When you think about it, she was just a niece. Whether he stepped up or not was up to him, but he would firmly stand in front of the younger generation.

Having such an elder was very reassuring.

"Oh, right." Xu Qingzhu said, "Uncle and I are going to join forces."

Liang Shi asked in surprise, "Join forces?"

"We're going to turn Haiwei Jewelry from rivals into friends. Uncle has been mentoring me recently." Xu Qingzhu said.

After reuniting with Su Yao, Xu Qingzhu hadn't been hiding things as much. She had heard so much about the history between Su Yao and Sheng Qinglin that she held a certain reverence for Su Yao.

And the reason Haiwei Jewelry had been able to develop so strongly over these years was largely thanks to Su Yao.

Su Yao, the genius designer once hailed as a "rising star" in the design world, had won awards in world-class competitions in her twenties, becoming a source of pride for Chinese people.

Although she had faded into obscurity under a hidden identity, over these years she had continuously produced designs.

She was Haiwei Jewelry's mysterious designer.

Minghui was too fragile right now, completely propped up by its former reputation. Never mind Haiwei—even a company with just a bit of a name, as long as they concentrated their firepower on Minghui, Minghui would have gone bankrupt and been liquidated long ago.

Even though things had improved somewhat after Xu Qingzhu joined the company, it wasn't something that could be changed overnight.

Chapter 112-5

The only person Xu Qingzhu could rely on was Su Zhe.

And joining forces with Su Zhe was nothing but beneficial for Minghui.

Recently, Xu Guangyao hadn't been coming to the company much, basically delegating all authority to Xu Qingzhu.

A few days ago, Xu Guangyao had actually taken Sheng Linlang out traveling. This left Xu Qingya coming home on the weekend only to find no one there. She even called Xu Qingzhu to complain, "Has our dad gone crazy? The workaholic has changed his ways?"

Xu Qingzhu laughed. "Maybe he wants to enjoy retirement life."

Xu Guangyao had essentially stepped back. There were still shareholders in the company who weren't convinced by Xu Qingzhu—after all, she was young and didn't have much hands-on experience. The autumn new product launch before had only let her show her potential; it wasn't enough to fully reassure people about her work capabilities. But Xu Qingzhu held a large number of shares, giving her absolute speaking power. In meetings, she used both kindness and authority.

Most importantly, she had the most important identity—the Sheng family heir.

This company would sooner or later be handed over to her.

With the support of her grandfather's old friends, she had more or less established a firm foothold in the company.

The cooperation with Su Zhe was also something she had never anticipated. For Haiwei to cooperate with Minghui now was blatant poverty relief¹.

When she said this to Su Zhe, Su Zhe laughed. "Anyway, half of all this belongs to your mother too. At worst, you'd just be squandering her half."

Su Zhe's ability in business operations was much stronger than Xu Guangyao's. At first, Xu Qingzhu was a bit embarrassed, but recently she had started going to Su Zhe with any questions. Su Zhe would answer wholeheartedly, and her path in the workplace had been almost smooth sailing.

She gave Liang Shi a brief summary, but Liang Shi suddenly said, "Can you really talk about this kind of business secret?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

After a silence, Xu Qingzhu said, "It's fine if you hear it. You wouldn't understand anyway."

Liang Shi: "?"

The car had just arrived at the entrance of the Japanese restaurant. Liang Shi parked by the roadside. With the engine off, there was no sound in the car. Liang Shi turned her head to look at Xu Qingzhu and said expressionlessly, "I see, so you're calling me stupid."

Xu Qingzhu chuckled. "How could that be?"

"I don't understand your stuff either." Xu Qingzhu said, "Everyone has their own strengths."

Liang Shi scoffed lightly, clearly not believing her words and feeling like she was just brushing her off. So she pressed, "Then what are my strengths?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Almost without thinking, Xu Qingzhu said, "Long hands."

.....

The car fell into a strange silence.

Liang Shi's ears suddenly turned red. Xu Qingzhu was caught in a peculiar embarrassment.

A few seconds later, Xu Qingzhu added, "Long legs too."

Liang Shi raised her hand and pinched her ear—this was her subconscious gesture.

But Xu Qingzhu smiled. "What? What are you thinking about?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"Nothing." Liang Shi retorted quickly, "You also have long hands and long legs."

"It's different." Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi: "What's different about it?"

Xu Qingzhu stared at her silently. After a moment, she suddenly leaned close to her, her lips only inches away from her ear.

The warm breath Xu Qingzhu exhaled landed on the tip of Liang Shi's ear, immediately making her ears even redder.

In this cramped space, Liang Shi wanted to retreat backward, but Xu Qingzhu's hand had already grabbed the clothes at her waist, pulling her closer.

In that instant, Xu Qingzhu's warm, moist lips touched Liang Shi's earlobe.

Liang Shi felt her heartbeat suddenly accelerate. She stared at Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu's hand fell into her palm, and in an extremely flirtatious tone, she said, "See, your fingers are longer than mine."

Liang Shi: "....."

1. "Poverty relief" (扶貧) here is used humorously/sarcastically to describe how the much stronger Haiwei Jewelry partnering with the struggling Minghui is essentially like charity work or helping a poor company. ⇐